

GORDHAN ZADAPHIYA

FORMER STATE HOME MINISTER



SHAILESH RAVAL

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Zadaphiya, now a rebel in an anti-Modi alliance, was minister of state for home during the 2002 riots. His name figures prominently in the

statement of Babu Bajrangji. Says Bajrangji, "After committing the massacre I called up the home minister and also VIP leader Jaideep Patel. I told the minister around 7 p.m. that we have killed so many people, so please take care of us. He told me to flee the place and save myself by hiding some where." Zadaphiya is tight-lipped on the issue. When pressed he says, "I didn't give any such advice or instructions to anybody during the riots. The courts and the Nanavati Commission are looking into the affair. I have nothing more to say." Interestingly, Zadaphiya, who has been close to VIP, has announced recently that he won't join any party nor contest the next election, but would help the anti-Modi forces by campaigning against the chief minister. Though Zadaphiya also held negotiations with some Congress leaders on behalf of the BJP rebels for seat adjustment, many Congressmen, particularly from minority communities and human rights activists, including Teesta Setalvad, had opposed his entry into the Congress on the grounds of his alleged role in the 2002 riots.

Legal status: No case was filed against him in connection with the Gujarat riots. He has however, been maintaining a low profile after the exposé.

ARVIND PANDYA

FORMER GOVERNMENT COUNSEL

Pandya, Gujarat Government counsel with the Nanavati-Shah Commission, was caught on the *Tehelka* sting tape that was aired on the Aaj Tak channel saying, "The report of the Nanavati-Shah Commission is going to come in the Government's favour because Shah is our man and Nanavati can be swayed with money. Modi was so enraged by the Godhra carnage that had he not been a minister, he would have himself gone and thrown bombs in Juhapura (a Muslim locality of Ahmedabad)." Pandya set off on an amazing damage control exercise within a day, saying that Dhimant Purohit, the Aaj Tak bureau chief at Ahmedabad and a friend, suggested to him he play the role of a government counsel in a television serial being made by Aaj Tak on the 2002 Gujarat riots titled "Madshow". Since Purohit was a friend, he said he accepted the offer and read the script in front of two unknown persons who had come to film the episode. Pandya said he was stunned to find later that this was being sold as a sting operation. After saying this at a press conference, the counsel resigned from his post. Aaj Tak on the other hand has denied Pandya's charge saying that it was a *Tehelka* sting operation in which no Aaj Tak scribe was involved.

Legal status: He is not an accused in any case.

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The exposé has come as a shot in the arm for human rights activists who want the accused in the Gujarat riots punished. But politically, it might turn out to be a windfall for Modi and his supporters on the eve of the Gujarat polls. Modi's supporters have their own arguments against the exposé. One, why didn't *Tehelka* do such an operation against the perpetrators of the Godhra massacre that triggered the reaction against the Muslims. Says state BJP spokesman Vijay Rupani, "It is part of the overall campaign to defame Modi. The same activists who are crying